he would know: Adelson has never lived in Israel, nor does he speak Hebrew, though his wife is Israeli.)

"Maybe you believe him, maybe you don't," said Oren Persico, a reporter for *The Seventh Eye*, a media monitor founded by the nonpartisan Israel Democracy Institute (it now publishes independently). "But he had a mission, and he did this on behalf of his close friend, the prime minister."

It was, and is, an expensive mission. *Israel HaYom* does not disclose its finances, but a former business partner revealed in a 2011 deposition that it loses $3 million per month. Adelson's generous subsidy does not just ensure positive press for the prime minister; it also allows the newspaper to kneecap its rivals, particularly *Yediot Aharonot*, which once boasted the country's largest readership (and thus its most lucrative advertising space). Since *Israel HaYom* is not subject to regular market forces, it can offer cut-price ads, driving down revenues across the industry. A 2014 report by *The Seventh Eye* found that a full-page advertisement in *Israel HaYom* could be bought for one-third of the price of a similar ad in *Yediot:* 25,000 shekels (about $6,400), compared to roughly 80,000 shekels.[14]

The paper is broadly right-wing, but not dogmatically so. One of its regular columnists is Yossi Beilin, the liberal politician who helped to negotiate the Oslo Accords. *Israel HaYom*'s only real ideology is loyalty to the prime minister. Many Israelis call it the "Bibiton", a portmonteau of Netanyahu's nickname and *eiton*, the Hebrew word for newspaper. Others are more blunt. Avigdor Lieberman, who grew up in the Soviet Union, has compared it to *Pravda*, the mouthpiece of the Communist Party. My colleague at *The Economist*, Anshel Pfeffer, reported in 2015 that its headlines are "routinely approved by the prime minister's office."

In late 2014, the Knesset began debating the loftily-named "law for the advancement and protection of written journalism in Israel." Despite the title, its purpose was quite narrow: the bill would have made it illegal to distribute free daily newspapers. Or at least some of them. Israel has a number of smaller free tabloids, like the *Post*, which is found mostly in convenience stores and gas stations. But the *Post* is only printed five days a week—so the authors of the bill defined a "daily newspaper" as one that publishes six times. Their definition also specified a minimum number of pages. The result was a bill that only affected a single newspaper, and thus quickly became known as the "*Israel HaYom* bill". It was sponsored by Eitan Cabel, a lawmaker from the opposition Labor Party, but it attracted